

diplomatic strategies and cooperation frameworks, and investigating the role of national courts and international organisations in promoting accountability.

Proposals may also incorporate participatory research approaches to enhance inclusivity and stakeholder engagement.

Proposals are encouraged to identify other relevant EU-funded projects related to EU democracy support, civil society engagement, and international cooperation on sustainable peace and democratic governance, and to explore potential collaboration opportunities with them.

The geographical scope of this research should include the EU Neighbourhood⁷⁰ and low- and lower middle-income countries⁷¹, with a focus on the Western Balkan and the accession countries. International cooperation is strongly encouraged.

HORIZON-CL2-2027-02-DEMOCRACY-09-two-stage: Open topic on reinvigorating and shielding European democracy

Call: Culture, Creativity and Inclusive Society - 2027 - Two-stage	
Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of between EUR 2.00 and 3.70 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 22.00 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Research and Innovation Actions
<i>Admissibility conditions</i>	The conditions are described in General Annex A. The following exceptions apply: Applicants submitting a proposal for a blind evaluation (see General Annex F) must not disclose their organisation names, acronyms, logos nor names of personnel in the proposal abstract and Part B of their first-stage application (see General Annex E).

⁷⁰ In the context of this call, the “EU Neighbourhood” is understood as the group of countries covered by the European Neighbourhood Policy (ENP), which includes countries to the East (Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, Georgia, Moldova, and Ukraine) and to the South (Algeria, Egypt, Israel, Jordan, Lebanon, Libya, Morocco, Palestine, Syria, and Tunisia). For more information: https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/european-neighbourhood-policy_en and https://north-africa-middle-east-gulf.ec.europa.eu/what-we-do/southern-neighbourhood_en

⁷¹ In the context of this call “low-income and low-middle income countries” are understood as the low to middle income non-associated third countries in the list of participating countries according to the Horizon Europe rules for participation and proposal procedure. Source: European Commission, “List of Participating Countries in Horizon Europe,” Version 5.3 (24.01.2024), p. 3. Available at: https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/docs/2021-2027/common/guidance/list-3rd-country-participation_horizon-euratom_en.pdf

<i>Eligibility conditions</i>	The conditions are described in General Annex B. The following exceptions apply: The Joint Research Centre (JRC) may participate as member of the consortium selected for funding as a beneficiary with zero funding, or as an associated partner. The JRC will not participate in the preparation and submission of the proposal - see General Annex B. In order to achieve the expected outcomes, consortia must include, as beneficiaries or affiliated entities, (i) at least one relevant public body with a policy-making role; and (ii) at least one relevant civil society organisation.
<i>Procedure</i>	The procedure is described in General Annex F. The following exceptions apply: The first-stage proposals of this topic will be evaluated blindly.
<i>Legal and financial set-up of the Grant Agreements</i>	The rules are described in General Annex G. The following exceptions apply: Eligible costs will take the form of a lump sum as defined in the Decision of 7 July 2021 authorising the use of lump sum contributions under the Horizon Europe Programme – the Framework Programme for Research and Innovation (2021-2027) – and in actions under the Research and Training Programme of the European Atomic Energy Community (2021-2025) ⁷². The granting authority may, up to 4 years after the end of the action, object to a transfer of ownership or to the exclusive licensing of results, as set out in the specific provision of Annex 5.

Expected Outcome: Projects should contribute to all of the following expected outcomes:

- EU institutions and national decision-makers, civil society organisations and other societal actors and citizens at large are better equipped, with new data, knowledge and methods, to confront threats and challenges of democracies as well as to enhance their inclusiveness and participatory elan.
- Strengthened citizens' long-lasting engagement in the democratic life, including but going beyond electoral processes, and increased trust in democratic institutions.

Scope: The Political Guidelines for 2024-2029 of the European Commission⁷³ announced a new **European Democracy Shield**. Building on the European Democracy Action Plan⁷⁴ and

⁷² This [decision](https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/docs/2021-2027/horizon/guidance/ls-decision_he_en.pdf) is available on the Funding and Tenders Portal, in the reference documents section for Horizon Europe, under 'Simplified costs decisions' or through this link: https://ec.europa.eu/info/funding-tenders/opportunities/docs/2021-2027/horizon/guidance/ls-decision_he_en.pdf

⁷³ https://commission.europa.eu/document/download/e6cd4328-673c-4e7a-8683-f63ffb2cf648_en?filename=Political%20Guidelines%202024-2029_EN.pdf

the Defence of Democracy Package⁷⁵, this initiative aims to safeguard, strengthen and promote democracy in the EU and to reinforce public trust. The Democracy Shield will aim to reinforce citizens' participation and engagement in the democratic life, promote free and fair elections and support free and independent media. It will also address the increasing threats to democratic systems, institutions and processes within the EU, often driven by various hostile actors aiming to undermine citizens' trust in democracy and its institutions. In addition, the Commission is also preparing a **Civil Society Strategy** and has also announced an updated strategy on LGBTIQ equality, a new anti-racism strategy, a new gender equality strategy, and a roadmap for women's rights⁷⁶ It also continues implementing the Strategy for the rights of persons with disabilities 2021-2030⁷⁷, in line with the United Nations Convention on the rights of persons with disabilities, which the EU and its Member States are parties to⁷⁸.

Ensuring full, equal and meaningful political participation for everyone, regardless of sex, gender, racial or ethnic origin, religion or belief, disability, socioeconomic status, employment or age, fosters more stable and resilient democracies. Decision-making processes that incorporate a wider range of perspectives and experiences leads to policies that are more comprehensive and attuned to the needs of all citizens.

Under this open topic, proposals should address existing, upcoming or unforeseen challenges and/or creative or disruptive solutions for protecting European democracy, enhancing citizens' trust and political participation, expanding inclusiveness and fairness of democratic institutions and practices and supporting and protecting civil society. Proposals are encouraged to investigate the opportunities offered by digital and other new technological solutions, notably from the civic tech sector. Proposals should address unmet research needs, complementing previous Horizon Europe calls.

In that sense, proposals should consider, **build on – if appropriate – while not duplicating, previous research**, including but not limited to, SSH disciplines and/or research by other Horizon Europe projects, in particular in the context of this destination. Coordination among the successful proposals from this topic should be envisaged to avoid duplication and to exploit complementarities as well as opportunities for increased impact.

Given the multifaceted character of the challenges confronted by democracies, applicants should ensure effective interdisciplinary collaborations by building consortia with the participation of all relevant disciplines, depending of course on the nature of the selected democratic challenge and research angle.

Applicants are encouraged to **adopt innovative approaches**, including also by **considering alternative and complementary models for democratic participation and engagement**, facilitating the development and potential uptake of solutions. To ensure the active

⁷⁴ https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_20_2250

⁷⁵ https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_23_6453

⁷⁶ For the roadmap for women's rights, see the announcement of its adoption with links to the communication and its annex: https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_25_681

⁷⁷ <https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=celex%3A52021DC0101>

⁷⁸ <https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/convention-rights-persons-disabilities>

involvement of and timely feedback from relevant democracy practitioners and policymakers, proposals should plan a mid-term deliverable consisting in the assessment of the project's mid-term contributions to the expected outcomes, performed by the democracy practitioners and policy-makers. Proposals should directly engage citizens, as well as civil society organisations, to enable broader public debate and explore uptake of democratic innovations and better anticipate potential risks.

Proposals are encouraged to collaborate with the JRC Competence Centre on Participatory and Deliberative Democracy, particularly with respect to demonstrating how structured opportunities for citizen participation strengthen inclusiveness and fairness of democratic institutions and practices, and foster evolution in democratic public spaces.

Where applicable, proposals should leverage the data and services available through European Research Infrastructures federated under the European Open Science Cloud (EOSC), as well as data from relevant Data Spaces. Particular efforts should be made to ensure that the data produced in the context of this topic is FAIR (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable and Re-usable).